

2026-09-06

DAILY EDITION

READ
LEARN
STAY INFORMED
GROW

IMPORTANT DEVELOPMENTS. BROADER PERSPECTIVES.

CURRENT AFFAIRS

DAILY DIGEST

NEWS THAT SHAPES A BETTER TOMORROW



POLITY &
GOVERNANCE



ECONOMY



INTERNATIONAL
RELATIONS



ENVIRONMENT



SCIENCE &
TECHNOLOGY



AGRICULTURE

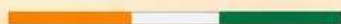


GEOGRAPHY



POLICIES &
SCHEMES

A MORE INFORMED
INDIA FOR A BRIGHTER
TOMORROW



PEOPLE
PLANET
PROGRESS



INNOVATION
FOR A STRONGER
TOMORROW



A MORE
PROSPEROUS
INDIA



SUSTAINABLE
GROWTH



OUR LAND
OUR HERITAGE



A HEALTHIER
PLANET

SAME FACTS. A BRIGHTER TOMORROW.

INDIA'S VULTURE CONSERVATION FROM CRISIS TO RECOVERY

Healthy Ecosystems | Safer Communities | A Vulture-friendly India

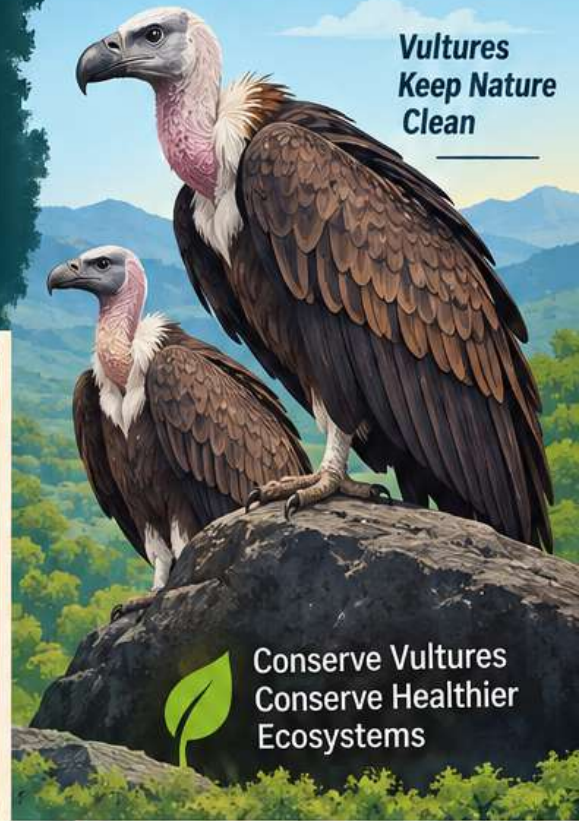
Vultures
Keep Nature
Clean

WHAT'S NEW?

6 September 2026



- Union Environment Minister inaugurated a national workshop at **Panchkula, Haryana** for **International Vulture Awareness Day 2026**.
- Workshop theme: **'From Crisis to Recovery – Conserving India's Vultures'**.
- Call for continued creation of **Vulture Safe Zones** and stronger technical capacity for species recovery in the wild.
- **Organised by:** Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, Central Zoo Authority, Haryana Forest & Wildlife Department, Bombay Natural History Society, and Jatayu Conservation Breeding Centre at Pinjore.



Conserve Vultures
Conserve Healthier
Ecosystems

WHY VULTURES MATTER



Scavengers rapidly dispose of carcasses.



Reduce disease risk for humans and livestock.



Help in nutrient cycling.



Indicator of ecosystem health.

WHY POPULATIONS CRASHED



Veterinary **diclofenac poisoning** through livestock carcasses was a major driver.



Habitat and food-chain pressures.



Unsafe carcass management and other threats.

VULTURE SAFE ZONE



- A landscape where threats are reduced, especially toxic veterinary drugs.
- Ensures safe food sources and proper carcass management.
- Involves monitoring, community participation and veterinary engagement.

INDIA FACTS

9

India has **nine vulture species**.

Examples:

- White-rumped Vulture
- Indian (Long-billed) Vulture
- Slender-billed Vulture
- Red-headed Vulture
- Egyptian Vulture
- Himalayan Griffon



CONSERVATION TOOLKIT



Captive breeding and reintroduction.



Drug safety and veterinary awareness (e.g. ban on diclofenac).



Habitat protection and safe carcass management.



Population monitoring and research.



Community participation and multi-stakeholder action.

PINJORE CENTRE



Jatayu Conservation Breeding Centre (JCBC) at Pinjore, Haryana

- A major conservation-breeding facility for vultures.
- In 2025–26, it housed **356 vultures** and bred **35 chicks**.



PRELIMS BOX



Vultures are birds of prey (raptors) and **scavengers**, not predators of live prey in normal circumstances.



Diclofenac residues in cattle carcasses can cause fatal kidney failure in vultures.



In-situ: Vulture Safe Zones (in the wild).
Ex-situ: Conservation breeding in facilities like JCBC, Pinjore.

Vultures Today
Healthier Tomorrows

SAVE VULTURES
SAVE ECOSYSTEMS
SAVE LIVES

INDIA – SRI LANKA

DEFENCE & MARITIME PARTNERSHIP

Stronger Neighbours, A Safer Indian Ocean

PEACE
STABILITY
PROSPERITY
IN THE INDIAN OCEAN

WHAT'S NEW?



Rajnath Singh visit:
8 – 10 Sept 2026



High-level India delegation

Including officials from Defence and External Affairs



Focus: defence + maritime cooperation

Will hold consultations with Sri Lankan leadership and interact with the Indian diaspora in Colombo.

INDIA AND SRI LANKA: KEY MARITIME GEOGRAPHY



WHY SRI LANKA MATTERS



India's closest southern maritime neighbour



Located beside key Indian Ocean sea lanes



Palk Strait & Gulf of Mannar link the two countries



Important for regional security and Indian Ocean stability

DEFENCE COOPERATION



SLINEX: India–Sri Lanka bilateral naval exercise



MITRA SHAKTI: bilateral army exercise



IN – SLN DIVEX: diving & submarine-rescue cooperation



HADR and maritime interoperability

STRATEGIC CONTEXT



Neighbourhood First



Security and Growth for All in the Region (SAGAR)



Maritime domain awareness



Countering non-traditional security threats

PRELIMS FACTS



Sri Lanka lies south of India



Palk Strait separates Tamil Nadu and Sri Lanka



Gulf of Mannar is between southeast India and western Sri Lanka



Colombo is a major Indian Ocean port

A STRONGER PARTNERSHIP
FOR A STABLE AND PROSPEROUS INDIAN OCEAN



INDIA-JAPAN

ELEVATE TIES TO A NEW STRATEGIC PHASE

During the recent visit of Japan's Prime Minister Shigeru Ishiba to India (5–6 Sept 2026), the two countries launched a new 10-year roadmap to deepen the India–Japan Special Strategic and Global Partnership.

STRONGER
PEOPLE • PROSPERITY
• A STABLE INDO-PACIFIC



‘VISION FOR THE NEXT DECADE’

A forward-looking plan to make India–Japan cooperation more ambitious, people-centric and impactful, anchored in shared democratic values.



PEOPLE-TO-PEOPLE & HUMAN RESOURCE MOBILITY

- Target to facilitate **500,000 people-to-people exchanges** in the next decade.
- Greater opportunities for students, skilled professionals and cultural exchanges.



ECONOMIC & INVESTMENT TIES

- Aim to invest **₹10 lakh crore** in India over the next 10 years.
- Focus on infrastructure, manufacturing, clean energy, semiconductors and startups.
- Stronger collaboration for resilient and diversified supply chains.



GREEN GROWTH & SUSTAINABILITY

- Enhanced cooperation in clean energy, energy transition and climate action.
- Collaboration on green hydrogen, battery technologies and sustainable infrastructure.
- Support for a low-carbon, climate-resilient and inclusive growth model.



DEFENCE & SECURITY COOPERATION

- Further strengthen defence and strategic ties.
- Greater collaboration in maritime security, a free, open and rules-based **Indo-Pacific**.
- Enhanced defence industrial cooperation and technology exchange.



TECHNOLOGY & INNOVATION

- Deeper cooperation in AI, semiconductors, quantum technologies, space and next-generation technologies.
- Joint research, innovation ecosystems and startup linkages.



REGIONAL & GLOBAL COOPERATION

- Reaffirm commitment to a free, open, inclusive and prosperous **Indo-Pacific**.
- Closer coordination in multilateral forums (**Quad, G20, UN**, etc.).
- Shared efforts for peace, stability and a rules-based international order.



TWO DEMOCRACIES. A STRONGER TOMORROW.

INDIA – JAPAN



GLOBAL BIOFUELS ALLIANCE

CLEAN ENERGY. STRONGER TOMORROW.

A global partnership led by India to accelerate the adoption of sustainable biofuels.



WHAT IS IT?



An international initiative launched by **India** in 2023 during the G20 presidency.



Aims to create a global ecosystem for production, use and trade of sustainable biofuels (bioethanol, biodiesel, SAF, biogas, etc.).



Brings together governments, international organisations, industry and research institutions.

MEMBERS

12 MEMBER COUNTRIES



India



USA



Brazil



Argentina



Canada



Italy



Mauritius



South Africa



UAE



Singapore



Bangladesh

and
1 more

INTERNATIONAL ORGANISATIONS



IEA

International
Energy Agency



IRENA

International Renewable
Energy Agency



FAO

Food and Agriculture
Organization

KEY FOCUS AREAS



Scale up production and use of biofuels (ethanol, biodiesel, SAF, biogas)



Facilitate technology development and knowledge sharing



Promote sustainable and resilient supply chains



Mobilise finance and investment



Develop common standards and certification



Support policy cooperation and capacity building

WHY BIOFUELS?



Lower greenhouse gas emissions



Cleaner air and better public health



Reduces dependence on imported fossil fuels



Helps rural economy and farmers (use of agri-residues like sugarcane, rice straw, etc.)

INDIA'S RELATED INITIATIVES



Ethanol Blending Programme (20% by 2025–26)



Sustainable Aviation Fuel (SAF) roadmap



Waste to Wealth Mission



National Bioenergy Programme



2G ethanol and advanced biofuel research

CHALLENGES



Sustainable and consistent feedstock supply



Higher production costs compared to fossil fuels



Need for advanced technology and infrastructure



Harmonising global standards



Balancing food security with biofuel expansion

FROM FIELDS TO A GREENER FUTURE

**BIOFUELS
DRIVE ENERGY SECURITY,
RURAL PROSPERITY AND
A CLEANER PLANET.**



SUSTAINABLE
ENERGY



STRONGER
FARMERS



CLEANER
ENVIRONMENT



A HEALTHIER
PLANET

INDIA LAUNCHES

MAITRI-II

A NEW ERA FOR INDIA'S POLAR RESEARCH

India's second indigenously built polar research vessel, MAITRI-II, has been launched, marking a major step in strengthening India's presence in the Antarctic and the Southern Ocean.



ABOUT MAITRI-II



Type: Polar Research Vessel (ice-class)



Built by: Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers (GRSE), Kolkata



Indigenously designed and built



Launched: September 2026



Purpose: Support India's Antarctic missions, scientific research and logistics supply

KEY FEATURES



Ice-breaking capability

Can navigate through sea ice in polar regions



Accommodation

For ~100 scientists, crew and support staff



Advanced laboratories

For oceanography, climate, marine biology and earth sciences



Helideck

Supports helicopter operations for logistics and research



Cargo capacity

Carries fuel, food and equipment for long-duration missions



Environment-friendly

Designed with low emissions and complies with modern environmental standards

INDIA'S ANTARCTIC PROGRAMME



Began in 1981 with the first Indian Antarctic Expedition



Research stations:

Maitri (1989) and Bharati (2012)



Focus areas: climate change, glaciology, oceanography, atmospheric sciences, biology and geology



Operated by: National Centre for Polar and Ocean Research (NCPOR), Ministry of Earth Sciences

WHY IT MATTERS



- Strengthens India's scientific research in the Antarctic and Southern Ocean



- Helps in better understanding climate change and its impact on India's monsoon and coastal regions



- Supports strategic presence in a resource-rich and geopolitically important region



- Enhances India's role in global polar governance and scientific collaboration



- Facilitates study of oceans, biodiversity and extreme environments

THE ANTARCTIC TREATY



- Signed in 1959, in force since 1961
- Designates Antarctica for peaceful purposes and scientific research
- Prohibits military activity, nuclear explosions and disposal of nuclear waste
- India is a Consultative Party (since 1983) with voting rights

A CLEANER, SAFER PLANET



- Polar research helps monitor global climate change
- Provides early warning for sea-level rise and extreme weather
- Contributes to a sustainable and resilient future



FROM THE POLAR OCEAN TO A SAFER TOMORROW

SCIENCE | SUSTAINABILITY | A STRONGER INDIA



INDIA'S NATIONAL CRITICAL MINERAL MISSION (NCCM)

SECURING RESOURCES FOR A SELF-RELIANT AND
CLEAN ENERGY FUTURE

CRITICAL
MINERALS
STRONGER INDIA

LITHIUM
COBALT
NICKEL
RARE EARTHS
COPPER
GRAPHITE
AND MORE

WHAT IS NCCM?



A flagship mission by the Government of India to ensure long-term and sustainable availability of **critical minerals** for India's **economic growth**, **clean energy transition** and **strategic autonomy**.

LAUNCHED



**JANUARY
2025**

Total outlay:

₹34,300 CRORE
(2025–2031)

WHY IT MATTERS?



Supports **clean energy** (renewable energy, EVs, energy storage)



Reduces **import dependence**



Enhances **strategic and economic security**



Enables **high-technology manufacturing**



Essential for India's **net-zero climate goal**

KEY OBJECTIVES



Increase domestic exploration and mining of critical minerals



Secure overseas mineral assets



Develop processing and recycling capabilities in India



Build a skilled workforce and strong R&D ecosystem

CRITICAL MINERALS INCLUDE



Lithium
(EV batteries)



Cobalt
(Batteries, superalloys)



Nickel
(Batteries, stainless steel)



Rare Earth Elements
(Magnets, electronics)



Copper
(Clean energy, electricals)



Graphite
(Batteries, nuclear)

MAJOR COMPONENTS



Geological mapping and mineral exploration



Acquisition of overseas mines and strategic partnerships



Setting up processing, refining and value addition facilities



Promoting recycling and urban mining



Research, innovation and skilling initiatives

RECENT DEVELOPMENTS



First set of critical mineral blocks identified for auction in India



Discussions underway for overseas assets in resource-rich countries (Australia, Africa, Latin America)



Focus on building domestic processing and refining capacity



Industry and global partners showing strong interest

THE BIGGER PICTURE

**CRITICAL MINERALS POWER
THE TECHNOLOGIES OF TOMORROW –
CLEANER PLANET,
STRONGER ECONOMY,
SECURE INDIA.**



RENEWABLE ENERGY



ELECTRIC VEHICLES



ELECTRONICS



DEFENCE



GREEN HYDROGEN



INDIA - EU

FREE TRADE AGREEMENT

A STRONGER PARTNERSHIP
FOR A MORE PROSPEROUS FUTURE

TRADE
PEOPLE
PLANET
PROSPERITY



LATEST DEVELOPMENT



Negotiations for the
India-EU Free Trade Agreement
(FTA) concluded in
September 2026.



The agreement is now moving
towards **legal review, translation
and formal approval.**

KEY FEATURES (REPORTED)



Reduction or elimination of tariffs
on majority of traded goods



Better market access for services
(IT, finance, professional services, etc.)



Facilitation of investments and
easier regulatory processes



Cooperation in technology, innovation
and digital trade



Focus on sustainable trade, clean energy
and critical raw materials



Provisions for labour rights, environmental
standards and inclusive growth

INDIA-EU TRADE: AT A GLANCE



EU is India's
largest trading partner.



Total trade (2024-25):
~€137 billion
(≈ ₹12.5 lakh crore)



India's exports to EU: **~€75 billion**



India's imports from EU: **~€62 billion**



EU accounts for **~17%** of India's
total trade.

WHAT IS IT?



A comprehensive trade agreement
to reduce tariffs, remove trade barriers
and deepen economic cooperation
between India and the European Union.

WHY IT MATTERS?



Creates new opportunities for Indian goods,
services and investments in the EU market.



Strengthens strategic partnership
democracies.



Supports resilient and diversified
global supply chains.



Helps in green transition, clean energy
and sustainable development.

KEY SECTORS THAT MAY BENEFIT



Textiles, leather, marine products



Automobiles and auto components



Pharmaceuticals and chemicals



Electronics and electrical goods



Agriculture and processed food



IT and business services



Gems and jewellery



Renewable energy and green technologies

THE ROAD AHEAD



- Legal scrubbing and translation
(of the agreement text)
- Approval by the European Council,
European Parliament and India's cabinet
- Final signing and ratification
- Implementation and monitoring
mechanisms



**DEEPER TIES
BRIGHTER OPPORTUNITIES**

**INDIA & EU
PARTNERS
IN PROGRESS**